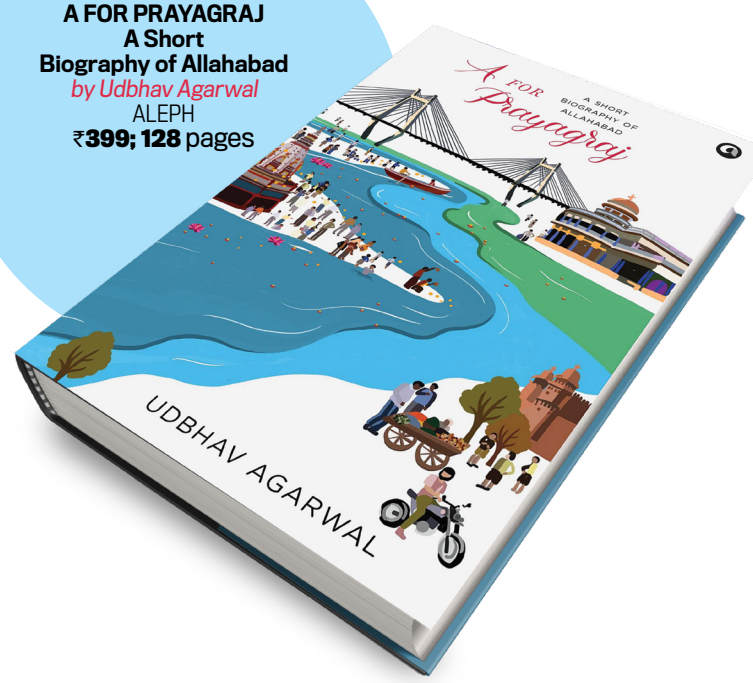
BOOKS

PRIDE IN PRAYAGRAJ

Allahabad might have changed its name, but a new book shows that the iconoclastic spirit of its youth remains resolute

A FOR PRAYAGRAJ
A Short Biography of Allahabad
by Udbhav Agarwal
ALEPH
₹**399; 128** pages



I might have said that this is a queer book, except that it would be an unforgivable pun. Well, today's paper reported a high court judge in Indore opining that in India "unmarried girls, regardless of their religion, [do not] indulge in carnal activities with boys just for the fun of it". Thanks to this book, I've got news for the learned judge.

Nostalgia is the default mode in which Allahabad is typically remembered. This nostalgia works at several levels. At the most accessible level, there is the nostalgia of the non-resident who, having been a student here before clambering into the civil service, remembers, in effect, his lost, receding youth. Receding not only as an effect of time passing but also because, like a lost civilisation, it is progressively buried under the debris of corruption and compromise.

There is something more at play in the idea of Allahabad—unlike, say, Banaras. The confluence has, no doubt, been a sacred site for millennia, but the riverbank is only a small part of Allahabad. There is another Allahabad—the city that came to be when the floodplain between the Yamuna and the Ganga was rendered habitable by Akbar's Bandh. It became the site of a great medieval city and, later, the crucial military base for the colonial fightback against the rebels of 1857. Subsequently, it became the capital of the North-West Province, and a whole 'white town'—the Civil Lines—came up to accommodate the servants of the Raj. This once-elegant enclave might soon find refuge exclusively in nostalgia. Because the great engines of '*vikaas*' are busily chewing up the guava orchards and the sprawling bungalows. In a way, then, Allahabad encapsulates, as a built environment, a long history. It is this history that is sought to be erased by the administrative transformation of Allahabad into Prayagraj, on the basis of a fake history that seeks to reduce this rich past to a bunch of religious predators and their funerary practices.

The young in Allahabad are staging plays and performances, like they were done 50 years ago, but now under deeply inhospitable circumstances



However, *A for Prayagraj* does neither nostalgia nor history. It offers, instead, a set of disconnected snapshots of something that might be called 'new Allahabad'. We see youngsters trying to do the same things—plays, performances—that some of us from the 'old Allahabad' were trying to do half a century ago but now under deeply inhospitable circumstances. But what is really 'new' here—and something of a revelation to an old-timer like myself (and I presume the high court judge to whom I am recommending the book)—is the presence of an active gay scene in my sleepy old town. There is a whole chapter dedicated to a Grindr date, but I'll leave it to the judge to decide whether boys doing it with boys fits in with his idea of "our" civilisation.

For the rest, there is a delicious buzz of malapropism in this slim text. Ceilings are described as "short", which must be the opposite of tall; the malls are "spanking", which makes retrospective sense, I suppose; but as for the clerks who are "splayed on the floor", the mind boggles. I could, alas, go on in this vein, but I'm reminded of *The Grammarian's Funeral*, and the *pandas* who have been plying their grim trade at the river's edge for millennia. ■

–Alok Rai